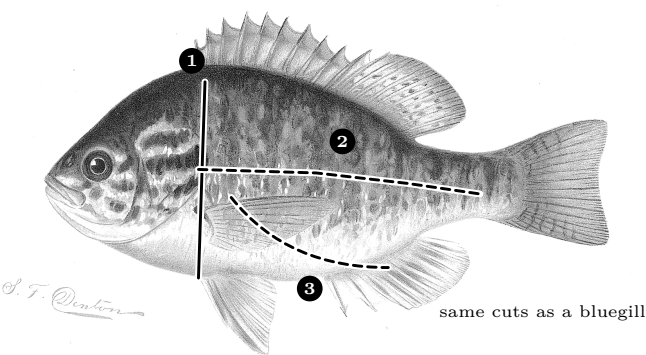


Cooking Pumpkinseed

Lepomis gibbosus — in the kitchen

Treat it exactly as a bluegill, because it is one for these purposes



Sunfish (*Eupomotis gibbosus*) — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Verdict	Indistinguishable from bluegill on the plate — sweet, white, delicate.
Size	Usually smaller than the bluegill it shares a bed with, which is the only practical difference. A 7 in pumpkinseed is a good one.
Yield	About 20%. Below 7 in, pan-dress rather than fillet.
Mixed catch	You will almost always be cleaning these alongside bluegill. There is no reason to separate them.
Hybrids	Bluegill and pumpkinseed interbreed freely. If a fish fits neither description, it eats the same either way.
Freezing	In water, not dry. Delicate flesh burns fast.

Filleting or pan-dressing

1. **Shear off the spiny dorsal** with kitchen scissors before anything else. It makes the fish safe to hold.
2. **Cut behind the gill plate**, following the gill cover’s curve, down to the backbone.
3. **Run the blade along the backbone** to the tail. The backbone sits high in a deep-bodied fish — aim higher than instinct suggests.
4. **Lift the ribs out** with a shallow arc.
5. **Skin from the tail.**
6. **Under 7 in, pan-dress instead:** scale against the grain with a knife back, gut, head off behind the gills, fins trimmed. Cook whole on the bone. More food and less work.

Bones and what to watch for

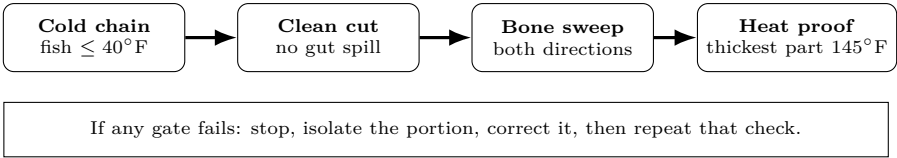
Spines	Sharp dorsal and anal spines. Shear them first.
Rib cage	Fine, easily removed.
No pin bones	Clean fillet.
Whole fish	The skeleton lifts out in one piece after cooking, which is the trick to show a child.

Cooking it

Method	How
Cornmeal-fried	Buttermilk, fine cornmeal, hot oil, two minutes a side. Exactly as bluegill. <i>see the Cooking Bluegill sheet</i>
Whole and crisp	Pan-dressed, scored, floured, shallow-fried until the fins crisp.
Mixed panfish fry	The normal outcome of a June evening: bluegill, pumpkinseed and a few crappie in one pan. No need to sort them.

Worth one lesson
Before you clean a June catch, sort the pile into bluegill and pumpkinseed by the ear flap — solid black versus an orange-red spot — and count each. It takes two minutes, it teaches an identification that sticks, and it tells you something real about which fish that bay is producing. <i>see the Pumpkinseed sheet</i>

Prove the meal before serving



Ask now	Pass condition	If it fails
Is the fish still cold?	Firm, clean-smelling flesh at or below 40 °F.	If time above 40 °F is uncertain, discard; do not try to “cook safety back in.”
Did the knife enter gut or gall?	No green stain, fecal material, or sour odor on edible flesh.	Cut away a generous contaminated margin; wash hands, knife, and board before touching clean meat.
Are the portions actually boneless?	Bright light plus two slow fingertip passes, head-to-tail and tail-to-head.	Return the portion to the clean board; trim or recut. Never rely on batter or sauce to hide a bone.
Is the center done?	A clean instant-read probe enters sideways into the thickest piece and reads 145 °F.	Keep cooking in short increments; clean the probe before rechecking.

Final proof

Set one finished portion on a clean plate, split its thickest point, and confirm opaque, separating flakes with no translucent core. Record the time and temperature once when learning a new pan, oven, or portion thickness. Cool leftovers shallowly and refrigerate within two hours. The proof is the measured center, not a timer, crust color, or confident guess.

Wisconsin safe-eating guidance. For bluegill, crappie, yellow perch, sunfish, rock bass and bullhead: **one serving per week** for women under 50 and children under 15; **unrestricted** for women over 50 and men. This is the statewide advice for inland waters, from the DNR and DHS *Choose Wisely* guide. Over 150 Wisconsin waters carry stricter site-specific advice — check the current booklet or the DNR’s Eat Your Catch query tool for these lakes before you make a habit of it.

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